create. As a result, economic and religious system frequently follows patterns of language distribution and political borders quite often parallel linguistic boundaries. In modern times linguistic diffusion has been facilitated by trade, tourism, media and international organizations. It has helped in the development of the linguistic pluralism. The greatest linguistic diversity is attributed to heterogeneous societies.



Tamil is one of the longest-surviving classical languages in the world. The earliest period of Tamil literature, Sangam literature, is dated from 300 BC (BCE) – AD (CE) 300. It has the oldest extant literature among Dravidian languages.

Major linguistic Families of the World

The classification of languages by origin and historical development is known as a genetic classification. The languages which are the descendants of common ancestral language are called proto – language.

G.L. Trage has classified the languages of the world into 7 linguistic phylum and 30 linguistic families. Linguistic families are further classified in to sub families of languages, which denote major languages.

1. Indo-European - a. Indo-Iranian, b. Latin or Romantic, c. Germanic, d. Balto –Slavic, e. Celtic, f. Hellenic
2. Sino-Tibetan - a. Chinese, b. Tibetan, c. Burman
3. Afro-Asiatic – a. Semitic, b. Egyptian, c. Cushitic, d. Chadic
4. African – a. Niger – Congo (Atlantic, Voltaic, Benu-Nagar)
   b. Sudanic (Chari-Nile, Saharan,)
   c. Click Languages (Khoisan)
5. Ural-Altaic - a. Finno-Igric, b. Turkic, c. Mangolic, d. Tunguzic
6. Dravidian- malayo – Polynesian- - a. Dravidian, b. Malayan, c. Melanesian, d. Micronesian, e. Polynesian, f. Austro-Asiatic.
7. Palaeo Asiatic- a.Yukaghir



As many as half of the world's 7,000 languages are expected to be extinct by the end of this century; it is estimated that one language dies out every 14 days.

Major Languages of India

India has a rich Linguistic heritage and has heterogeneous ethnic and social groups, which have their own languages and dialects. According to census of India 1961, there were 187 languages spoken by various sections of Indian society. 23 major languages were spoken by about 97 percent population of the country. 22 languages excluding English are mentioned in the eighth schedule of the constitution of India as follows; Kashmiri, Punjabi, Hindi, Urdu, Bengali, Assamese, Guajarati, Marathi, Kannada, Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, Sindhi, Sanskrit, Oriya, Nepali, Kongani, Manipuri, Bodo, Dogri, Maithili and Santali of these languages, 14 were initially included in the Constitution. Subsequently, Sindhi was added in 1967 by 21st constitutional amendment act; Konkani, Manipuri and Nepali were added in 1992 by 71st Constitutional Amendment Act; and Bodo, Dogri, Maithili and Santali were added in 2003 by 92nd Constitutional Amendment Act. Indian Languages belong mainly to four linguistic families

1. Austric – Munda, Mon-Khmer
2. Dravidan – Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Gondi, kurukh, orean, etc.
3. Sino- Tibetan- Bodo, Karen, Manipuri, etc.
4. Indo - Aryan – Hindi, Urdu, Sans.

TN_GOVT_XII_Geography_chapter 05.indd 99 12/6/2022 6:01:52 PM